minds about Tibetan claims on Sikkim as well as the Anglo-Chinese discussions in earlier periods that had led to the 1890 and 1906 Conventions between Britain and China.

The Sikkim issue remained dormant after the 1962 border conflict, aside from the skirmishes between the Indian and Chinese forces along the Tibet-Sikkim boundary until 1973, when the Chinese grew concerned about India's attempts to change the status quo. The story of Sikkim's merger with India has been beautifully narrated by a number of those who were involved in the process, and it is not the subject of this book. Suffice to say that the process that commenced in May 1973 with the signing of the Tripartite Agreement, awoke the Chinese to a new situation developing on their Tibet frontier. A flurry of media attacks followed, labelling Indian activity in Sikkim as 'expansionist' and even drawing comparisons between the Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia in 1968 in the name of protecting socialism and Indian action in Sikkim in the name of promoting democracy. [9] Some Chinese media pieces suggested that this was a Soviet plot to encircle China. The Chinese Communist Party mouthpiece, the *People's Daily*, called the merger 'a flagrant act of colonial expansion', [10] darkly warning India's other neighbours that what was being done by India to Sikkim would one day befall them as well. Chinese concerns over the changing status quo also figured in conversations with the Americans. In his talk with Secretary of State Dr Henry Kissinger in November 1974, Vice Premier Deng Xiaoping wondered aloud as to why India had wanted to annex Sikkim when they already had good control over it, and described Indian policy as 'something peculiar'. [11] Ambiguity over the status of Sikkim, which had served China well until 1974, was no longer tenable. On 11 September 1974, the Chinese Foreign Ministry issued a statement: 'The Chinese Government solemnly states that it absolutely does not